

the minorities once had in the party is now all but gone. Says Dinesh Trivedi, Trinamool Congress MP, "With the SEZ issue, the support of the minorities has been reduced to half of what the Front had earlier." Counters Mohammad Salim, CPI(M) MP: "The violence is no reflection on minorities' anger against us. The problem was fomented by those with no mass support."

Also indicative of Buddhadeb's growing unpopularity and lack of a commanding influence is that while nobody raised questions about the army deployment in 1992 when Basu was at the helm, this time, Buddhadeb is facing awkward questions as to why his government and the police were totally lacking in intelligence inputs and preparedness to control what is one of the worst days that Kolkata has seen.

Incidentally, according to police sources, some of the around 100 people arrested, upon questioning, did not even know what they were fighting for and had no answer when asked

why they had taken to the streets in a fashion unheard of in Kolkata's recent history. This has been lumpenisation at its worst and could not have come at a worse time for the beleaguered chief minister considering the political connotations. The All-India Minority Commission (AIMC) President Idris Ali, who has switched from the Congress to the Trinamool Congress and is now back again with the Congress, says, "We planned this agitation demanding resignation of the chief minister for the Nandigram violence and demanding cancellation of the visa of Taslima Nasreen, who had made blasphemous remarks on Islam." The Jamiat-e-Ulamae-Hind President Siddiquallah Chowdhury, who has had a leading role to play against the state Government over the Nandigram issue, however, said, "Though we do not support this agitation, it clearly reflects the outburst of the people against the CPI(M). But this agitation will not last. And if we were behind this, the

protest would have been bigger." Asked why he had no control on his supporters when he had organised the protest, Ali said, "Intruders sneaked into our rally. We do not know who did this and who are to be blamed."

With Wednesday's violence, the rift within the Front has again come out in the open after RSP Minister Kshiti Goswami volunteered to resign in protest against Buddhadeb's handling of the Nandigram issue. Almost all the parties of the Front, while condemning the violence, made it clear that the people of the state had a "tradition of living in harmony" but stopped short of hauling the government over the coals.

Shorn of its politics, Buddhadeb and the Left Front's decline is seen as a larger and more complex issue. Says filmmaker Goutam Ghosh, "It's actually a socio-economic problem. The Front has been in power for more than

THE LEFT FRONT RECORD OF VIOLENCE IS LONG AND BLOODY

1979: Rehabilitation unfulfilled for Dandakaranya refugees. Mass murder and mayhem, as cadres and police evicted them.

1982: Seventeen Anand Margis burnt alive in Kolkata by CPI(M) cadres for "inciting" people against the Left Front.

2000: Tussle over land in Birghum, Keshpur and Garbeta met with bloody deaths. Official records are still missing.

2001: In Chhoto Angria village, CPI(M) goons set people and houses afire. Number of deaths remains unknown.

2007: Trouble starts in Nandigram over land, simmers for 11 months. CPI(M) goons "recapture" the area; loot and murder. Total dead: Unconfirmed.

TURNING POINT:
Nandigram becomes a rallying point for Left Front opponents

